

Northern Pike

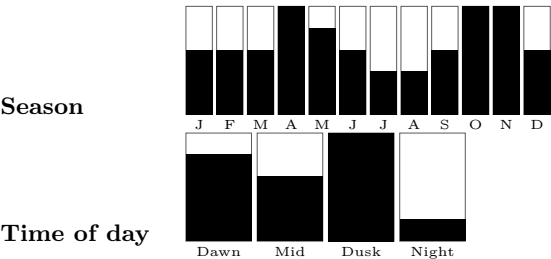
Esox lucius

First to spawn, last to quit — Pine Lake & North Lake



The Pike — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

- Tell it apart** Light bean-shaped spots on a dark green body — light-on-dark. The cheek is fully scaled and the lower half of the gill cover is bare. Five sensory pores along each side of the lower jaw.
- Not a musky** A musky is the photographic negative: *dark* marks on a *light* body, the lower half of both the cheek and gill cover bare, and six to nine pores per side. At a 40 in minimum on musky and 26 in on pike, this matters.
- Size here** 20–30 in is the working range; 36 in and up is a real fish. State record 38 lb.
- Spawn** The first gamefish to go, immediately after ice-out at 40–45 °F, in flooded marsh grass and shallow vegetation — often before the ice is fully gone from the main lake.



Where

- Pine** Spots **1** and **9** in spring and fall, **5** along the deep weed edge in summer. In a lake this cold and clear, the largest pike go deep and cool in July and August — 25–40 ft on the edge of the basin, not in the shallows.
- North** Spots **2** (outlet), **5** (the neck) and **6** (river inlet). Current and weed. This lake fishes more like a classic pike water than Pine does.
- Cover** Weed edges, points, and any narrows. Pike are ambush hunters that want a wall at their back and open water in front.

How

- Cover water** A large spinnerbait or a spoon over and along the weed tops. Fast, snag-resistant, and it finds the aggressive fish.
- Big fish** A large sucker on a quick-strike rig under a float, *see the **quick-strike rig** sheet*. This is how most of the biggest pike in these lakes are taken.
- Ice** Tip-ups with a live shiner set just off the bottom along the weed edge, *see the **tip-up** sheet*.
- Leader** **Always.** A wire or heavy fluorocarbon leader. Pike teeth cut straight line, and losing a fish with a hook in it is a bad outcome for the fish, not just for you.

HANDLING A PIKE

The teeth are backward-facing and will cut you to the bone. Long pliers and jaw spreaders, always; fingers never go in the mouth or under the gill plate. Support a big fish horizontally with a wet hand under the belly. Above roughly 70 °F a released pike is fragile — unhook it in the net, in the water, and let it go.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 26 in minimum, 2 per day, open 2 May–7 March. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*